

Almond and butternut tarts

Tartes de amêndoa e abóbora

Makes 4

For the filling

3 ounces/80 g butternut squash, peeled
and cut into small pieces
1 tablespoon olive oil
7 tablespoons/90 g superfine sugar,
plus 1 teaspoon
A pinch of smoked paprika
6½ tablespoons/90 g butter, softened,
plus extra for greasing
2 eggs
4 ounces/125 g ground almonds
3 tablespoons/30 g all-purpose flour
Finely grated zest of 1 orange

For the topping

5 tablespoons/70 g butter
6 tablespoons/75 g superfine sugar
5 ounces/150 g sliced almonds
5 teaspoons/25 ml whole milk
Confectioners' sugar, for dusting

Early one morning, after antique hunting at the Feira da Ladra flea market, I stopped at a café for a coffee and had the perfect almond tart. The nuts were crisp and the filling was crumbly and buttery, flavored with almond and orange. As I sat there in the sunshine I promised myself I'd make my own version as a tribute to that moment.

Preheat the oven to 430°F/220°C (convection 390°F/200°C) and grease four 5-inch/13-cm tart tins with butter.

To make the filling — Put the butternut squash on a baking sheet and toss with the olive oil, the 1 teaspoon of sugar, and the paprika. Roast for 30 minutes, or until soft and caramelized. Purée with an immersion blender until smooth.

Cream the butter and the remaining 7 tablespoons/90 g of sugar until light and fluffy. Add the eggs one by one. Stir in the ground almonds. Fold in the flour, then the butternut squash purée and the orange zest. Divide the mixture evenly among the tins and bake for 10 minutes, or until just set.

To make the topping — Melt the butter and sugar in a small pan over low heat. When the sugar has dissolved, stir in the almonds and milk and cook for a few minutes, stirring constantly. Divide the topping among the tarts and bake for 4 more minutes.

I like to dust the tarts lightly with confectioners' sugar when they come out of the oven. Leave them to cool for a few minutes before taking them out of the tins; the topping will firm as it cools.

